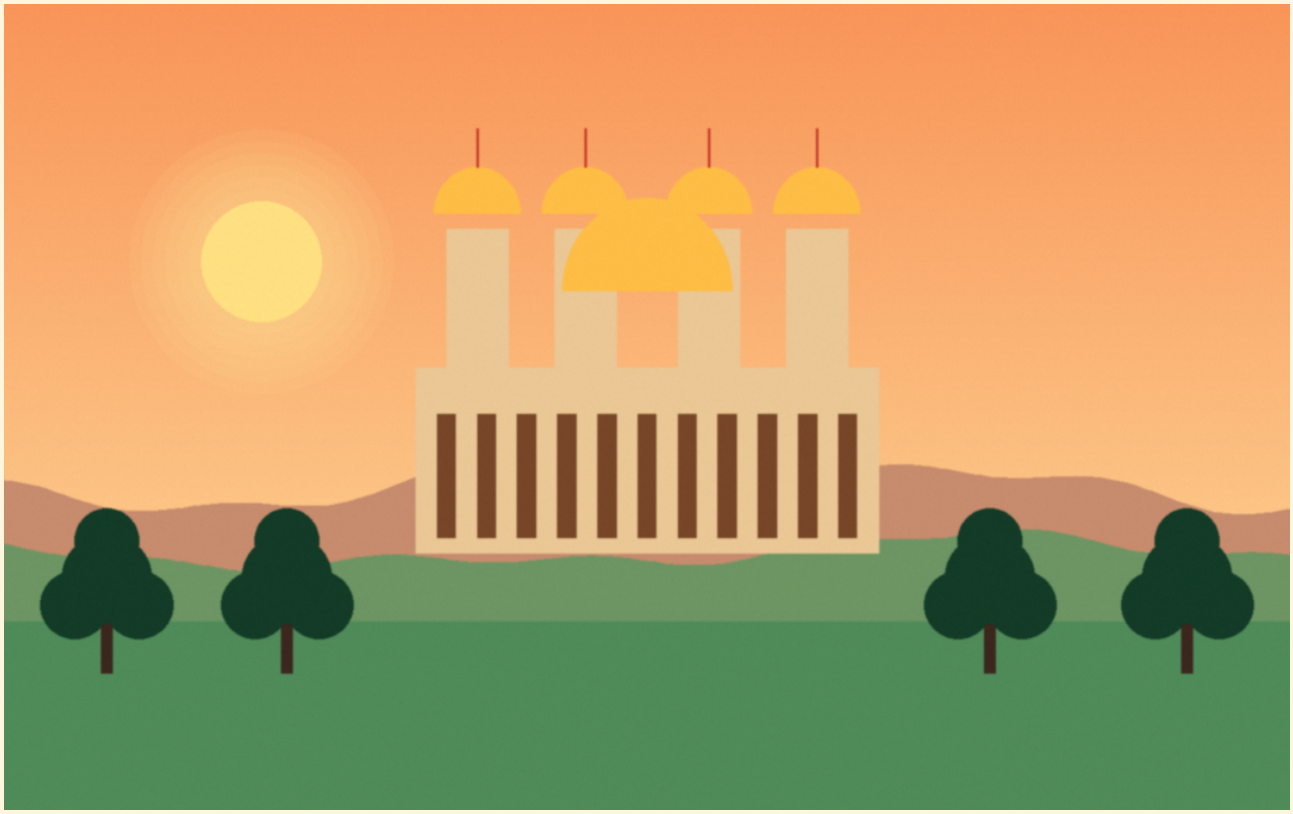
THE RAMAYANA

The Epic Tale of Rama, Sita and Hanuman

A Short Story Retelling

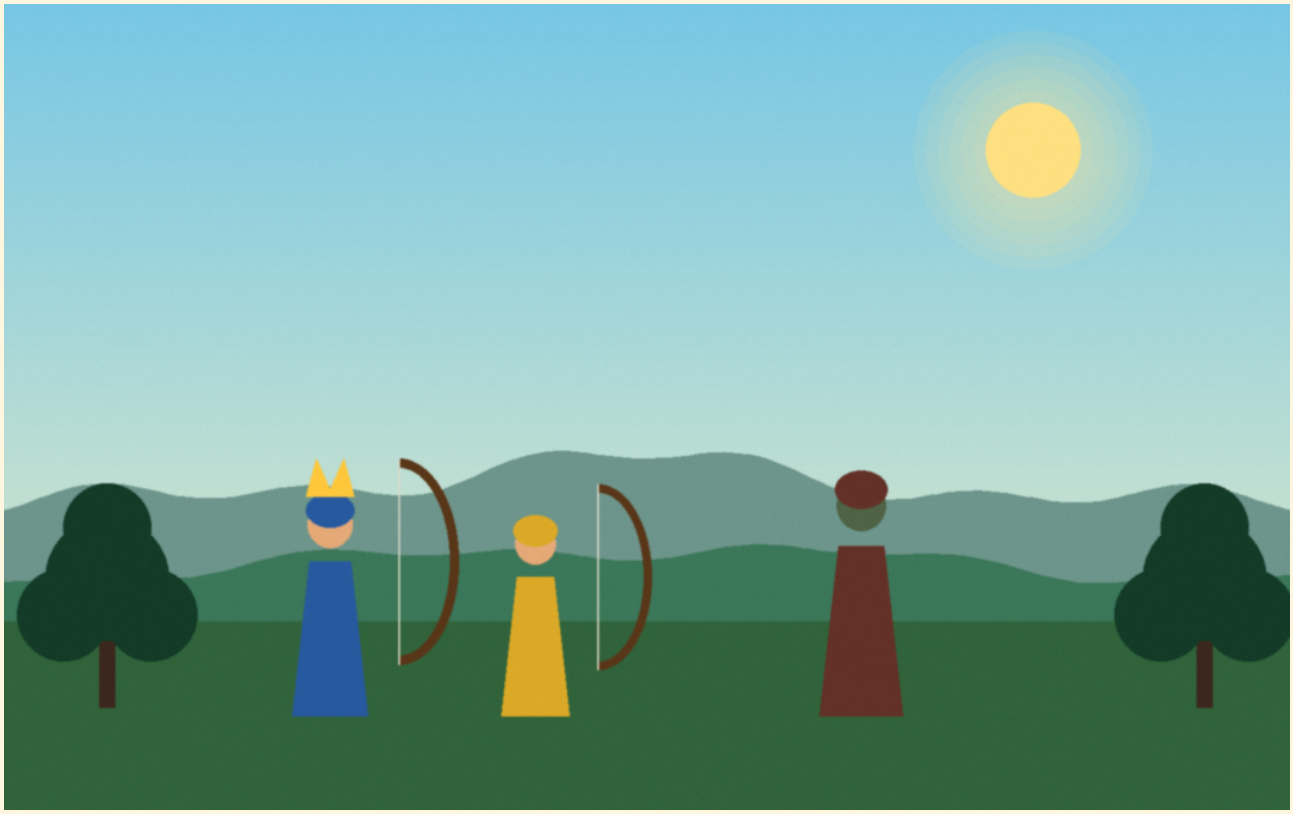


Prologue: The Jewel of Kosala

Long ago, on the banks of the river Sarayu, stood the golden city of Ayodhya. Its streets were wide and bright, its gardens full of peacocks, and its people lived without fear. King Dasharatha ruled with a gentle hand, and the land loved him for it. Yet the king carried one quiet sorrow: he had no son to carry his name. In his three queens, Kausalya, Sumitra and Kaikeyi, he found great comfort, but the palace halls echoed with no children's laughter. One evening, as the sun melted into the river, the king bowed his head and prayed for an heir who would be worthy of the throne and of the people's trust.

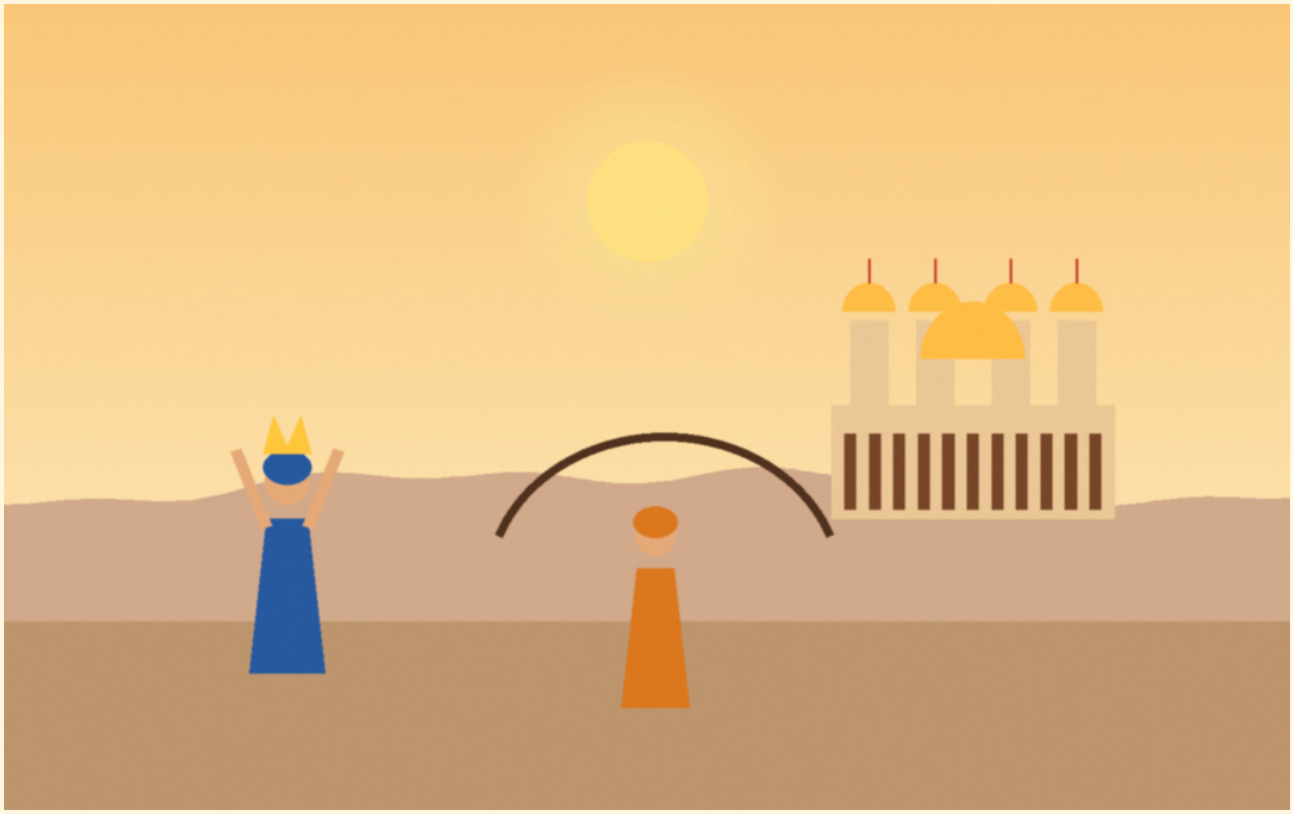
Chapter 1: Four Little Lights

The sage Rishyashringa performed a great sacred fire, and from the flames rose a radiant being carrying a golden bowl of sweet pudding. The king shared it among his queens, and in time four sons were born. Kausalya gave birth to Rama, calm and shining like the morning moon. Kaikeyi gave birth to Bharata, humble and true. Sumitra blessed the kingdom with twins, Lakshmana and Shatrughna. The four boys grew up as one heart in four bodies. Yet Lakshmana's love for Rama was deepest of all; wherever Rama walked, Lakshmana followed, like a shadow that never fades at noon.



Chapter 2: The Sage's Request

One day the mighty sage Vishwamitra arrived at the palace gates. Demons were disturbing his sacred rites in the forest, and he asked for young Rama's help. Dasharatha trembled, for Rama was barely a youth, but the sage's gaze was steady and the king finally agreed. Rama and Lakshmana set out together, bows on their shoulders. In the deep forest the fearsome demoness Tataka rushed at them with a roar that shook the trees. Rama, remembering his duty to protect the innocent, raised his bow and released a single arrow. The forest grew still, and the sage's rites went on in peace.

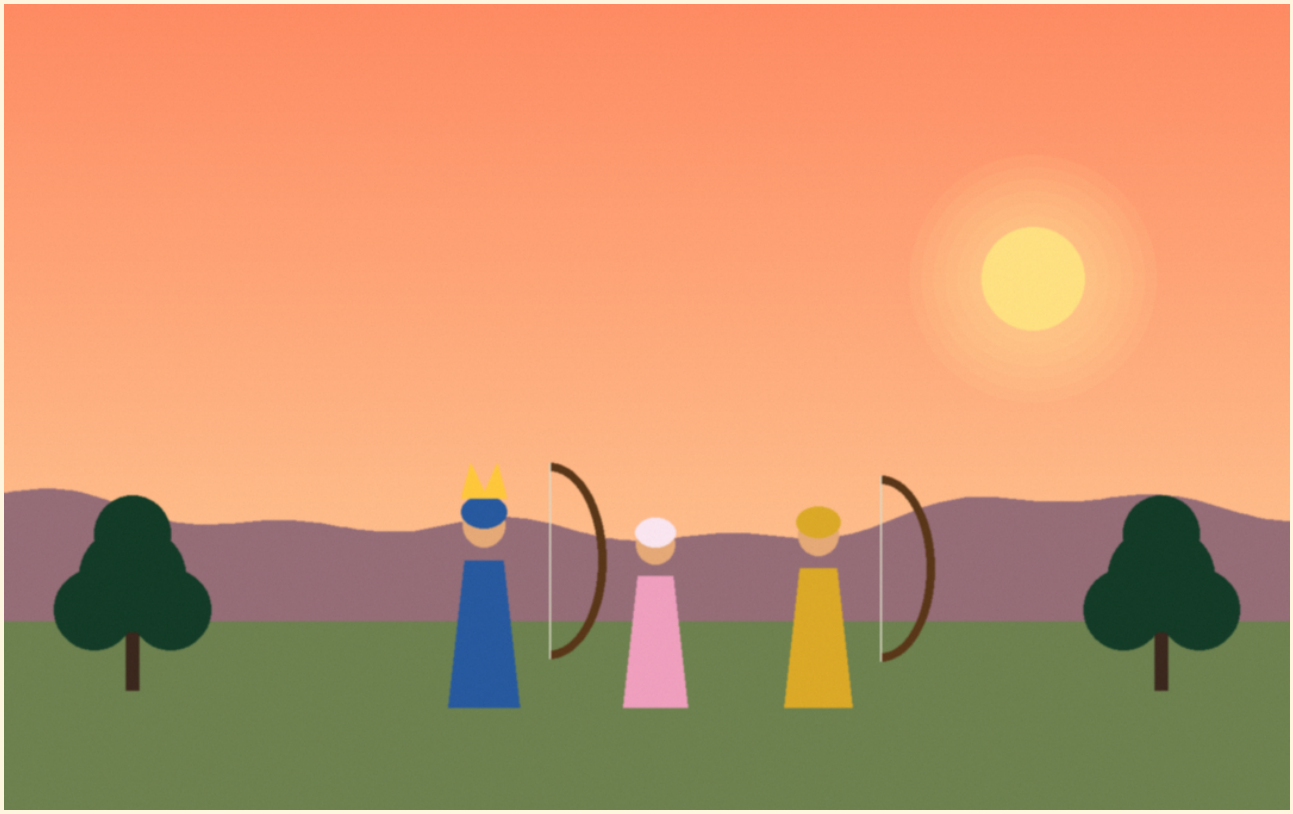


Chapter 3: The Bow of Shiva

From the forest, Vishwamitra led the brothers to the city of Mithila, where King Janaka was holding a great gathering. In his hall rested the colossal bow of Lord Shiva, so heavy that eight hundred men were needed to roll it in. Janaka's daughter Sita, wise, kind and radiant, would marry only the one who could lift and string it. Princes from many lands tried and failed. Then Rama stepped forward, lifted the bow as lightly as a reed, and bent it to string it. With a thunderous crack it broke in two. Sita placed a garland of flowers around Rama's neck, and Mithila rang with joy.

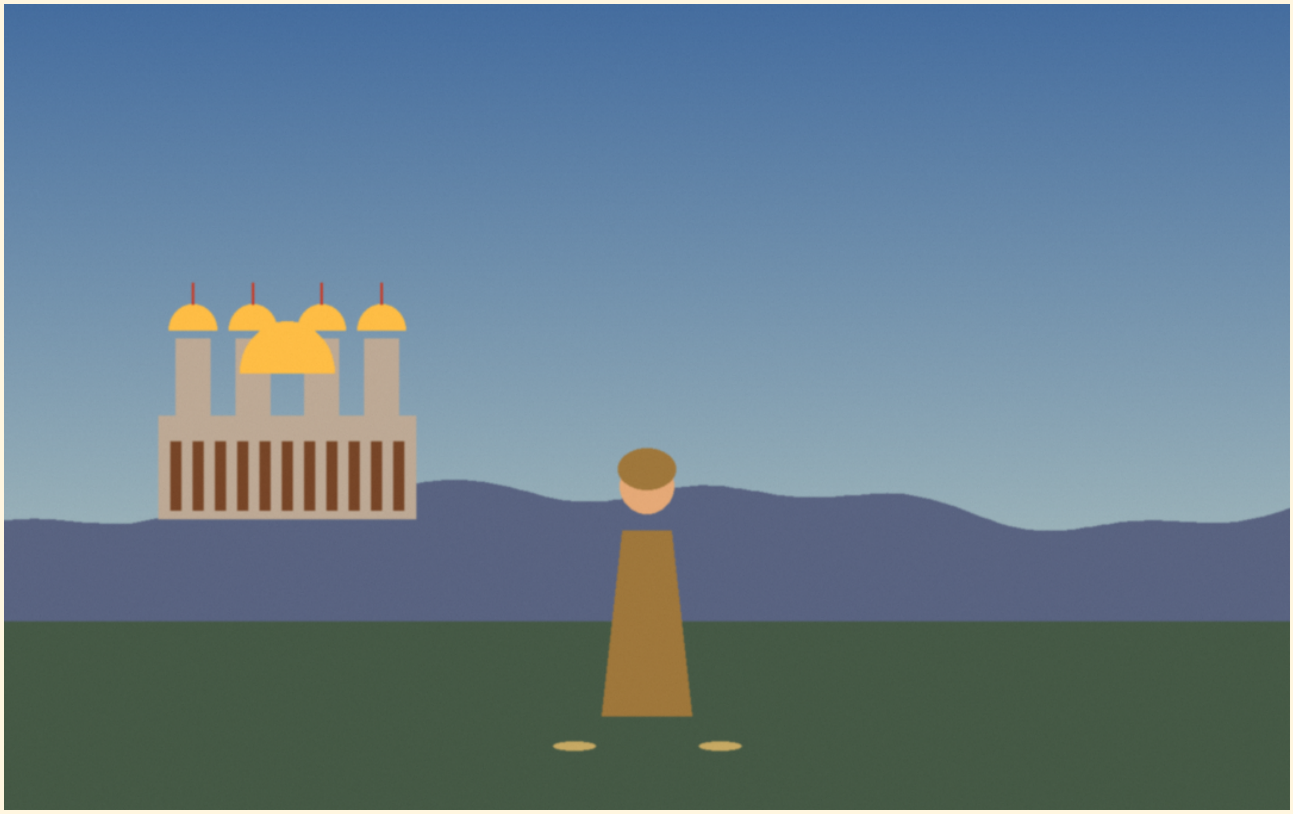
Chapter 4: The Promise of Kaikeyi

Years of happiness passed in Ayodhya. At last Dasharatha, growing old, decided to crown Rama as king, and the whole city glittered with preparations. But Kaikeyi's maid Manthara whispered poison into the queen's ear, until fear and jealousy darkened her heart. She remembered two boons the king had once promised her. Now she claimed them: Bharata must be crowned, and Rama must live in the forest for fourteen years. Dasharatha fell to the floor, broken. He had given his word and could not take it back. The torches of celebration were quietly put out, one by one.



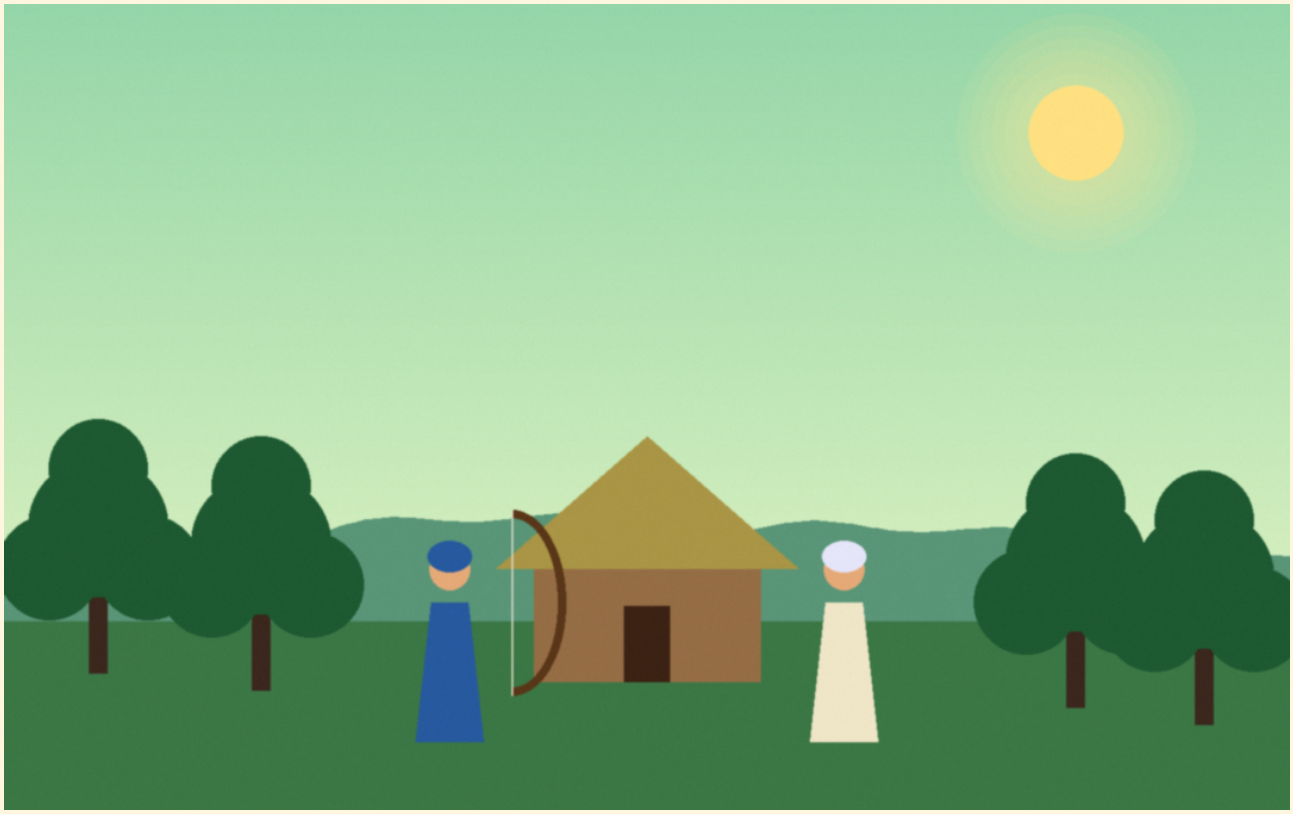
Chapter 5: Into the Forest

Rama heard the decree with a calm face. 'A promise must be kept,' he said, and he laid down his royal robes without a single complaint. Sita refused to remain behind. 'Where you go, I go,' she said, 'for a forest with you is a palace.' Lakshmana, too, would not be left. At dawn the three left the city in simple bark clothes, while the people of Ayodhya wept in the streets and followed the chariot as far as they could. That night, on the far bank of the river, the exiles slept beneath the stars, and Ayodhya felt empty as a lamp without oil.



Chapter 6: The Sandals of Rama

King Dasharatha could not survive the grief of parting and soon passed away. Bharata, who had been away from the city, returned to find his father gone and his brother exiled. He was filled with anger and shame at what his mother had done. He rushed into the forest and begged Rama to return and rule. Rama gently refused; his father's word had to be honoured. With tears in his eyes, Bharata asked for Rama's wooden sandals instead. He placed them on the throne and ruled only as Rama's servant, living like a hermit outside the city until his brother should come home.

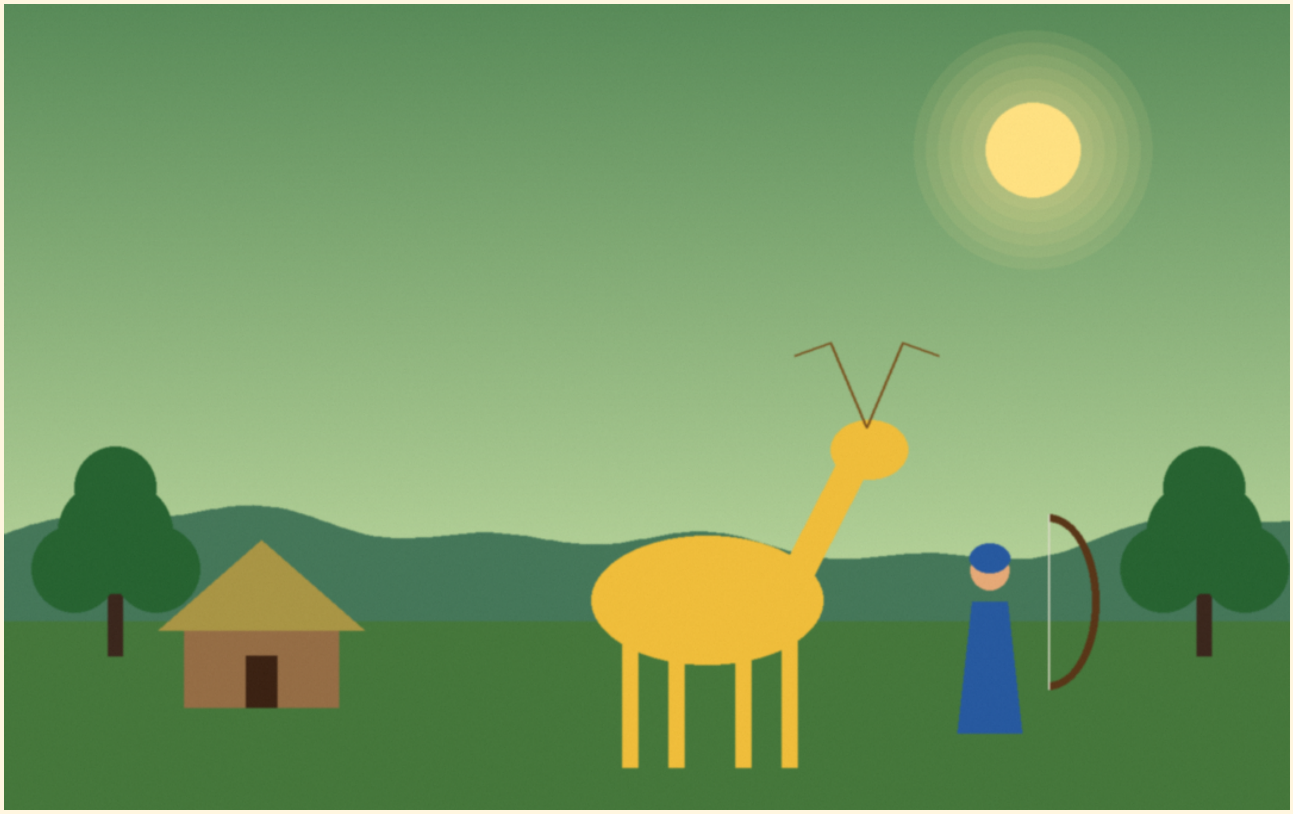


Chapter 7: Life at Panchavati

Rama, Sita and Lakshmana wandered through the forests, meeting sages and helping them. At last they settled by the river Godavari, at a place called Panchavati, where five great banyan trees gave shade. Lakshmana built a little cottage of leaves and wood, and the three lived there in peace. Deer ate from Sita's hand, peacocks danced in the rain, and the days were full of birdsong. Years slipped by like leaves on a stream. Neither the cold of winter nor the heat of summer could trouble hearts so filled with love, and for a while it seemed as if the sorrow of Ayodhya was far away.

Chapter 8: The Demoness Surpanakha

One day a demoness named Surpanakha, sister of the ten-headed king Ravana, saw Rama in the forest and fell in love at once. Rama smiled and told her he was already married. She turned to Lakshmana, but he refused her too. Furious, she rushed at Sita, and Lakshmana was forced to protect her, wounding the demoness before she fled. Weeping with rage, Surpanakha flew to Lanka and told her brother everything. She described the beauty of Sita so vividly that Ravana's heart filled with desire and pride. A storm of trouble was gathering over the peaceful forest.



Chapter 9: The Golden Deer

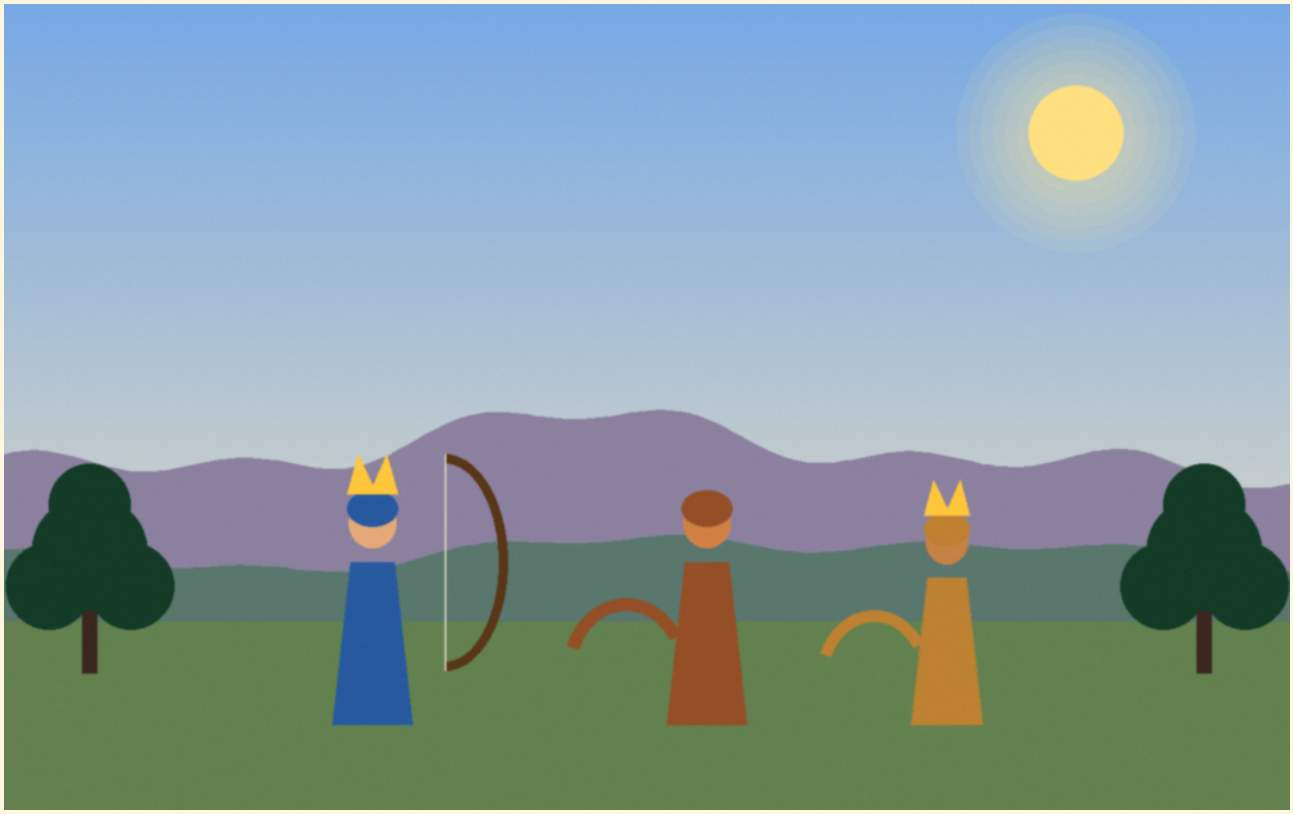
Ravana, the mighty king of Lanka, sought the help of the magician Maricha. 'Become a golden deer and wander near Sita's cottage,' he commanded. Maricha obeyed with a heavy heart. One morning Sita saw a marvelous deer whose coat shone like sunlight, and she begged Rama to catch it for her. Rama sensed deceit, but he went. 'Guard her, Lakshmana,' he said. Deep in the forest, the deer fell to Rama's arrow, crying out in Rama's own voice, 'Sita! Lakshmana!' Back at the cottage, Sita heard the cry and trembled.

Chapter 10: The Line of Fire

Sita begged Lakshmana to go to Rama's aid. Lakshmana knew his brother was invincible and the cry was a trick, but Sita's tears and her sharp words made him give way. Before leaving, he drew a circle on the ground around the cottage. 'Do not step outside this line, whatever happens,' he said. As soon as he had gone, a wandering holy man appeared at the door, begging for alms. It was Ravana in disguise. When Sita stepped across the line to give him food, he shed his disguise, seized her, and rose into the sky in his flying chariot.

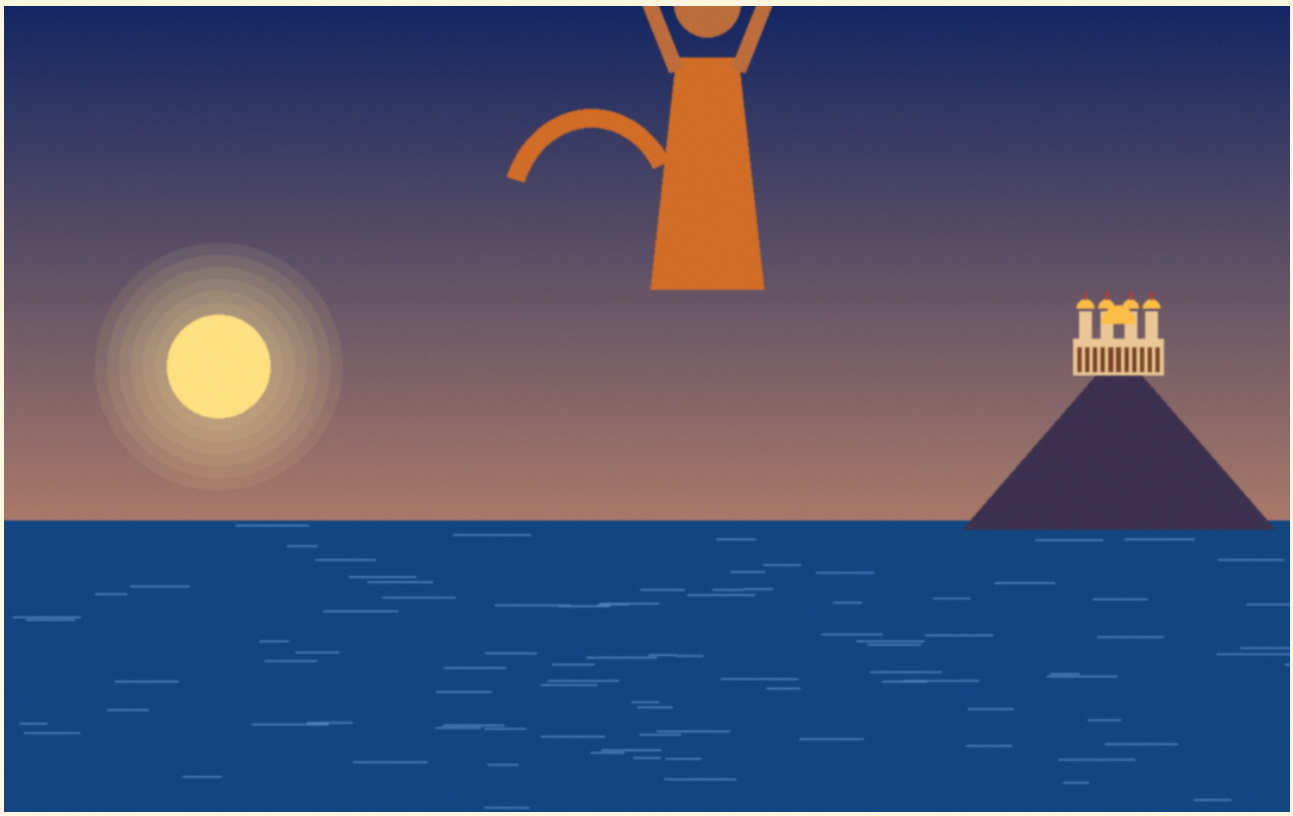
Chapter 11: Jatayu's Last Flight

Sita's cries echoed across the sky. The great old vulture Jatayu, a friend of Dasharatha, heard her and flew to her rescue, though he was ancient and weak. He tore at Ravana's chariot and wounded the demon king, but at last Ravana's sword cut off his wings and he fell to the earth. Sita dropped her jewels in a cloth so that they might mark her path. When Rama and Lakshmana returned, they found the empty cottage and the dying bird, who whispered, 'Ravana has taken her south.' Rama laid his friend to rest with honour and swore to find Sita.



Chapter 12: Hanuman, the Wind's Son

Searching south, the brothers reached the mountain kingdom of Kishkindha. There they met a young monkey of immense strength and gentle heart: Hanuman, son of the Wind. The moment he saw Rama, he bowed down in deep devotion. Hanuman brought the brothers to the monkey king Sugriva, who had been driven from his throne. Rama helped Sugriva regain his kingdom, and in return Sugriva promised the entire monkey army to find Sita. From every corner of the land, monkeys and bears gathered, ready to search the world, and Hanuman was given Rama's ring to carry to Sita as a sign of faith.

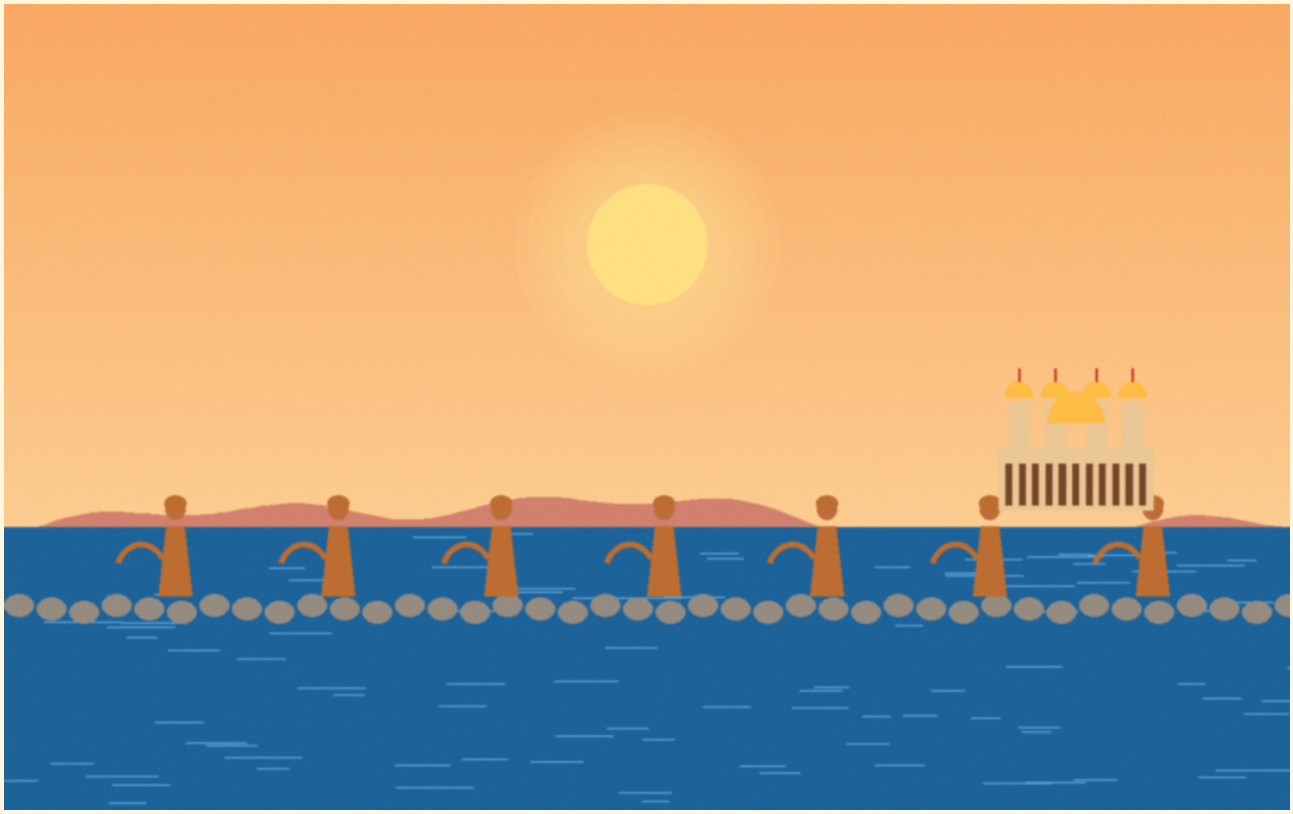


Chapter 13: The Leap Across the Ocean

The searchers reached the southern shore and found the ocean stretching to the horizon. No one could cross it. The old bear Jambavan reminded Hanuman of his own forgotten powers. 'You can leap over the sea,' he said. Hanuman grew larger and larger until he stood tall as a mountain. He bowed to Rama far away, then sprang into the air with a roar. The sea-goddess and a mountain rose to help him rest, and a sea-demon tried to swallow him, but Hanuman shrank, slipped out of her mouth, and flew on. At last the golden towers of Lanka glittered in the distance.

Chapter 14: The Grove of Ashoka

Hanuman shrank to the size of a cat and crept through Lanka by night, searching every palace. At last he found Sita in the Ashoka grove, thin and sad, guarded by fierce demonesses. Hidden in a tree, he softly sang of Rama until she looked up. He gave her Rama's ring, and her eyes filled with tears of joy. 'Tell Rama I am alive and waiting,' she said, handing him a jewel from her hair. Before leaving, Hanuman wrecked the garden to show Ravana his power. The demons tied burning cloth to his tail, but he leapt across the rooftops and set the golden city ablaze.



Chapter 15: The Bridge of Stones

Hanuman returned with the news, and Rama's heart lifted like a sail in the wind. The vast monkey army marched to the sea. Rama prayed to the ocean for three days, but it did not part. At last he raised his bow in anger, and the sea-god rose in fear, advising that Nala, the monkey builder, could build a bridge. Monkeys carried boulders and trees and wrote Rama's name on every stone, and the stones floated. In five days a great causeway stretched across the waves, and the army crossed over to Lanka, banners flying, cries of victory shaking the sky.

Chapter 16: The Battle of Lanka

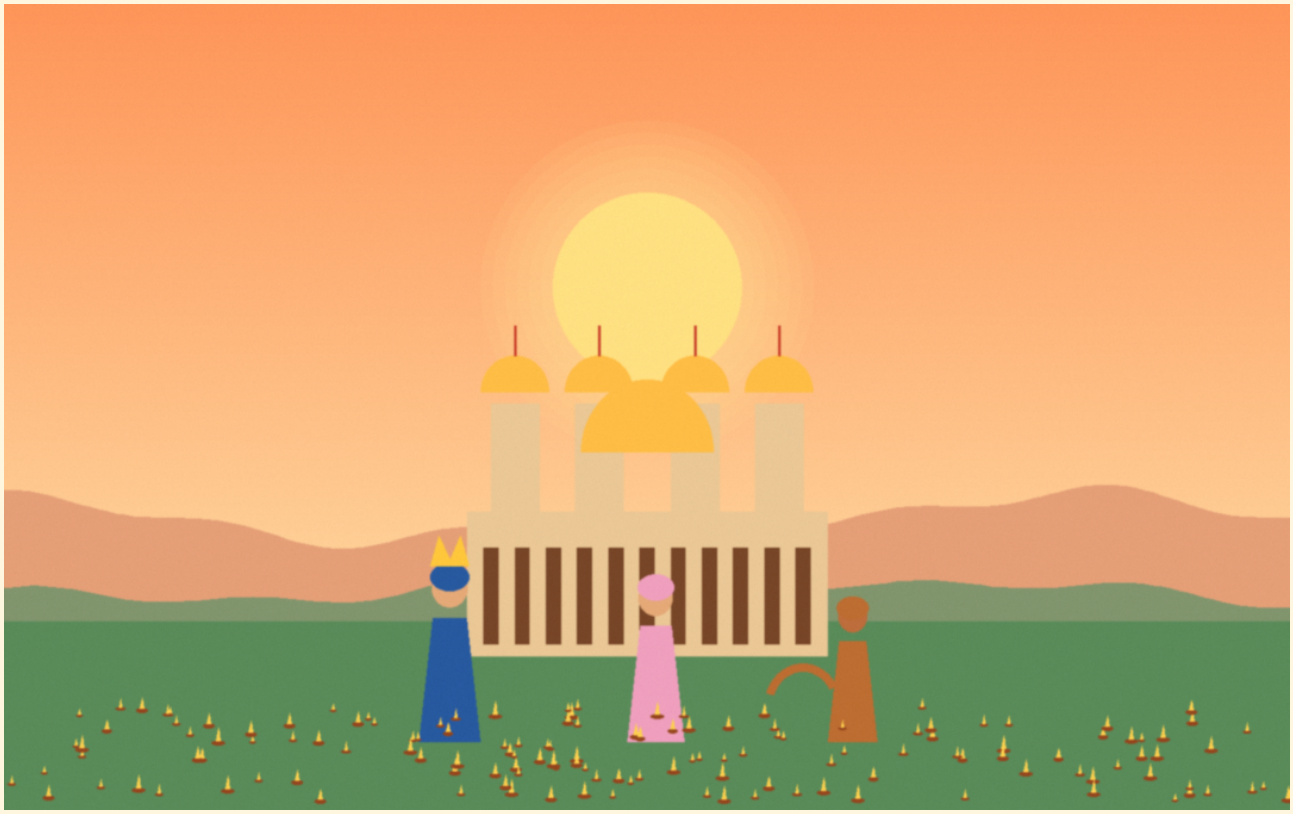
A great war began beneath the walls of Lanka. Ravana's sons and generals poured out, one after another, and one after another they fell. Ravana's brother Vibhishana, who loved truth, left his proud brother and joined Rama. In the fiercest battle, Ravana's son Indrajit struck Lakshmana with a deadly weapon, and the prince fell as if dead. Only the herb Sanjeevani, growing on a distant Himalayan mountain, could save him. Hanuman flew north at once, but not knowing which herb it was, he lifted the whole mountain and carried it back. Lakshmana woke, and the army roared in triumph.

Chapter 17: The Fall of Ravana

At last Ravana himself rode out, ten heads gleaming and twenty arms bristling with weapons. The duel between him and Rama shook heaven and earth. Whenever Rama cut off one of Ravana's heads, another grew in its place. Then Vibhishana whispered the secret: Ravana's life was hidden in his navel. Rama raised a divine arrow, blessed by the sage Agastya, and let it fly. It struck true, and the great king of Lanka fell. The demons wept and the gods rained flowers from the sky. Rama gave Ravana a proper funeral, for even in victory, he honoured courage in an enemy.

Chapter 18: The Return to Ayodhya

Sita, free at last, came before Rama, and the long separation ended. The fourteen years of exile were complete. Riding in the flying chariot Pushpaka, Rama, Sita, Lakshmana and Hanuman soared home across the land. Far below, Bharata saw the chariot approaching and ran to meet his brother with the wooden sandals held high. The two embraced and wept. That night, the people of Ayodhya lit thousands of clay lamps along every street, window and rooftop, so that the whole city shone like a river of stars. This is why we light lamps for Diwali, the festival of lights.



Epilogue: The Light That Remains

Rama was crowned king, and his reign, called Rama Rajya, was remembered for ages as a time of justice, peace and kindness. Farmers prospered, children laughed, and no one went hungry. The Ramayana teaches that truth keeps its shine even in the darkest forest, that a promise is a sacred thing, that love between brothers is stronger than any crown, and that devotion, like Hanuman's, can move mountains. Each generation tells this tale again, for stories like this are lamps passed from hand to hand. May the light of Rama's story shine in your heart, too.